

Imminence No Date Setting

doc-imminence-no-date-setting
Eschatology · Return of Christ · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.950
confidence high

Statement under examination

Christ's return is imminent and could occur at any time, but no one knows the day or the hour, and date-setting is forbidden.

In plain language

The question is whether the Bible teaches that Christ's return could happen at any time, that no one knows the exact day or hour, and that setting a date is forbidden. Reading only the Greek text and standard lexical tools, two threads run through the passages. First, knowledge of the timing is denied. Matthew 24:36 and Mark 13:32 say οὐδεις οἶδεν, no one knows, about the day (ἡμέρα) and hour (ὥρα). The word οὐδεις is a universal negative, and Mark stacks the denials so that not the angels and not even the Son know, only the Father. In Acts 1:7 Jesus tells the disciples οὐχ ὑμῶν ἐστιν γινῶναι χρόνους ἢ καιρούς, it is not yours to know the times or seasons, placing them in the Father's own authority. Paul echoes the same word pair, χρόνος and καιρός, in 1 Thessalonians 5:1 and says no calendar letter is needed. Second, the response commanded is watchfulness, not calculation. Matthew 24:42 uses the present imperative γρηγορεῖτε, keep watching, grounded by you do not know the day. Mark 13:33 adds βλέπετε, ἀγρυπνεῖτε, watch and stay alert, because you do not know when the time is. The arrival is pictured as a thief in the night, ὡς κλέπτῃς ἐν νυκτὶ, in both Matthew 24:43 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2, an image of unannounced timing. Matthew 24:44 says be ready (ἔτοιμοι) because the Son of Man comes at an hour you do not expect (οὐ δοκεῖτε). Philippians 4:5 says ὁ κύριος ἐγγύς, the Lord is near, James 5:8 ἡ παρουσία τοῦ κυρίου ἥγγικεν, has drawn near, and Revelation 22:20 ἔρχομαι ταχύ, I come swiftly. Together the lexical pattern is decisive that the day and hour are not humanly knowable and that fixing a date is outside the believer's province, while constant readiness is commanded. One nuance explains why readers diverge on the strength of any-moment language. 2 Thessalonians 2:1-3 inserts an ordering adverb πρῶτον (first) with an ἀποστασία and revelation of the ἄνθρωπος τῆς ἀνομίας before the day of the Lord. The text supplies an unannounced arrival pattern and also a signs-first pattern, and the words themselves do not rank the two. So no-date-setting is settled, readiness is settled, generic nearness is settled, but strict any-moment expectation with no prior conditions is the element the canon leaves room around.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0069	ἀγρυπνέω	agrupneo	be watchful	4
G0199	ἀκριβῶς	akribōs	exactly	
G0458	ἀνομία	anomia	lawlessness	
G0601	ἀποκαλύπτω	apokaluptō	to reveal	
G0646	ἀποστασία	apostasia	apostasy	
G0991	βλέπω	blepo	to see	136
G1097	γινώσκω	ginosko	to know	222

G1125	γράφω	graphō	to write	
G1127	γρηγορέω	gregoreo	to keep watch	23
G1380	δοκέω	dokeo	to think	63
G1448	ἐγγίζω	engizo	to come near	43
G1451	ἐγγύς	engys	near	30
G1492	οἶδα	oida	to perceive	318
G2064	ἔρχομαι	erchomai	to come/go	640
G2092	ἔτοιμος	hetoimos	ready	17
G2250	ἡμέρα	hemera	day	392
G2540	καιρός	kairos	time/right time	84
G2812	κλέπτης	kleptes	thief	16
G2962	κύριος	kurios	lord	
G3756	οὐ	ou	no	
G3761	οὐδέ	oude	nor	
G3762	οὐδείς	oudeis	none	233
G3952	παρουσία	parousia	coming	
G3962	πατήρ	pater	father	426
G5035	ταχύ	tachy	quickly	10
G5207	υἱός	huios	son	386
G5550	χρόνος	chronos	time	53
G5610	ώρα	hora	hour	108

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The proposition has two limbs and the lexical pattern lands them very differently. The no-date-setting limb is decisive across multiple authors. Matthew 24:36 and Mark 13:32 use the universal negative pronoun οὐδείς with the perfect οἶδεν of the day (ἡμέρα) and hour (ώρα), Mark stacking οὐδὲ ... οὐδὲ to deny even the Son. Acts 1:7 says οὐχ ὑμῶν ἐστὶν γινῶναι χρόνους ἢ καιροὺς οὓς ὁ πατήρ ἔθετο ἐν τῇ ἰδίᾳ ἐξουσίᾳ, removing the times and seasons from the disciples' competence. Paul reuses the same χρόνος and καιρός pair in 1 Thessalonians 5:1 and adds the thief simile of 1 Thessalonians 5:2. Watchfulness is commanded with present imperatives γρηγορεῖτε (Matt 24:42), βλέπετε ἀγρυπνεῖτε (Mark 13:33), and γίνεσθε ἔτοιμοι (Matt 24:44). The any-moment imminence emphasis is real but more synthetic. The thief simile and watch-imperatives plus Phil 4:5 ἐγγύς, Jas 5:8 ἤγγικεν, Rev 22:20 ἔρχομαι ταχύ support nearness and readiness, while 2 Thess 2:1-3 inserts an ordered ἀποστασία and revelation of the ἄνθρωπος τῆς ἀνομίας before the day comes, so strict any-moment expectation is in tension with at least one sequence statement in the canon.

Scripture

Matt.24.36 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3762 οὐδείς, G1492 οἶδα, G2250 ἡμέρα, G5610 ὥρα, G5207 υἱός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. The verse opens with *περὶ δὲ τῆς ἡμέρας ἐκείνης καὶ ὥρας* and then negates knowledge with *οὐδείς οἶδεν*. The pronoun *οὐδείς* is a universal negative, so the perfect *οἶδεν* (MorphGNT codes V- 3XAI-S--, perfect active indicative third singular, the standard stative perfect meaning to know) is denied to every named party, the angels of heaven and even the Son, leaving *εἰ μὴ ὁ πατήρ μόνος*. The day and hour are explicitly named as the unknown items, which fixes the non-knowledge limb of the proposition lexically.

Matt.24.42 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1127 γρηγορέω, G1492 οἶδα, G2250 ἡμέρα, G2064 ἔρχομαι

Force. The present active imperative *γρηγορεῖτε* commands continuous watchfulness, and the causal *ὅτι* clause grounds it in *οὐκ οἴδατε ποῖα ἡμέρα ὁ κύριος ὑμῶν ἔρχεται*. The interrogative *ποῖα ἡμέρα* makes the unknown a specific calendar item, and the present *ἔρχεται* keeps the coming in view as something that can break in at any time. The watchfulness imperative is presented as the direct response to not knowing the day.

Matt.24.43 · for · genre: gospel · figures: simile

Key terms. G2812 κλέπτῃς, G1492 οἶδα, G5610 ὥρα, G1127 γρηγορέω

Force. The simile likens the coming to a thief, *εἰ ἦδει ὁ οἰκοδεσπότης ποῖα φυλακῇ ὁ κλέπτῃς ἔρχεται, ἐγρηγόρησεν ἄν*. The pluperfect *ἦδει* in a contrary-to-fact condition states that the householder did not know the watch, and the apodosis with *ἐγρηγόρησεν ἄν* makes watchfulness contingent on that ignorance. The κλέπτῃς image encodes unpredictability of timing.

Matt.24.44 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1380 δοκέω, G5610 ὥρα, G2064 ἔρχομαι, G2092 ἔτοιμος, G5207 υἱός

Force. The conclusion *γίνεσθε ἔτοιμοι* uses the predicate adjective *ἔτοιμος* of readiness and is grounded by *ὅτι ἢ οὐ δοκεῖτε ὥρα ὁ υἱὸς τοῦ ἀνθρώπου ἔρχεται*. The verb *δοκέω* marks the hour as one the hearers do not expect, and the present *ἔρχεται* again presents the coming as possible at an unanticipated hour. Readiness is commanded precisely because the hour is not predictable.

Acts.1.7 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G1097 γινώσκω, G5550 χρόνος, G2540 καιρός, G3962 πατήρ

Force. Jesus answers the disciples' restoration question with *οὐχ ὑμῶν ἐστὶν γινῶναι χρόνους ἢ καιροὺς οὓς ὁ πατήρ ἔθετο ἐν τῇ ἰδίᾳ ἐξουσίᾳ*. The negated possessive *οὐχ ὑμῶν* plus the aorist infinitive *γινῶναι* removes the knowing of times and seasons from the disciples' province, and the relative clause assigns those *χρόνοι* and *καιροί* to the Father's own authority. This is the direct lexical ground for forbidding speculation or date-setting about the timing.

1Thess.5.1 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5550 χρόνος, G2540 καιρός, G1125 γράφω

Force. Paul writes *περὶ δὲ τῶν χρόνων καὶ τῶν καιρῶν, ἀδελφοί, οὐ χρειάν ἔχετε ὑμῖν γράφεσθαι*. The same *χρόνος* and *καιρός* pair as Acts 1:7 appears, and Paul says no calendar instruction needs to be written, which presupposes that fixing the time is not the church's task. The lexical overlap with Acts ties the two passages on the question of timing.

1Thess.5.2 · for · genre: epistle · figures: simile

Key terms. G2250 ήμέρα, G2812 κλέπτῃς, G0199 ἀκριβῶς

Force. Paul states αὐτοὶ γὰρ ἀκριβῶς οἶδατε ὅτι ἡμέρα κυρίου ὡς κλέπτῃς ἐν νυκτὶ οὕτως ἔρχεται. What they know precisely (ἀκριβῶς) is not the date but the manner, that the day of the Lord comes like a thief in the night. The κλέπτῃς ἐν νυκτὶ simile reuses the Matthew 24:43 image and encodes unannounced arrival, supporting imminence without a knowable date.

Mark.13.32 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3762 οὐδεὶς, G1492 οἶδα, G2250 ἡμέρα, G5610 ὥρα, G5207 υἱός

Force. Mark's parallel is fuller, περὶ δὲ τῆς ἡμέρας ἐκείνης ἢ τῆς ὥρας οὐδεὶς οἶδεν, οὐδὲ οἱ ἄγγελοι ἐν οὐρανῷ οὐδὲ ὁ υἱός, εἰ μὴ ὁ πατήρ. The οὐδεὶς plus the stacked οὐδὲ ... οὐδὲ exhausts the candidates and ascribes knowledge only to the Father. This is the strongest single statement of the non-knowledge limb in the canon.

Mark.13.33 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0991 βλέπω, G0069 ἀγρυπνέω, G2540 καιρός, G1492 οἶδα

Force. The application βλέπετε, ἀγρυπνεῖτε pairs two present imperatives of vigilance, grounded by οὐκ οἶδατε γὰρ πότε ὁ καιρός ἐστίν. The interrogative πότε plus the negated οἶδατε states that the time is unknown, and βλέπω plus ἀγρυπνέω (a rare verb, only four occurrences in the Greek NT, three of them with eschatological or prayer alertness force) command continuous alertness as the response. This matches the Matthew 24:42 γρηγορεῖτε pattern with a second vigilance verb.

Phil.4.5 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1451 ἐγγύς, G2962 κύριος

Force. Paul writes ὁ κύριος ἐγγύς, the Lord is near, with the adverb ἐγγύς. Whether the nearness is temporal (return soon) or spatial (presence near), the temporal reading is well attested for ἐγγύς when paired with day or coming language, and the immediate ethical exhortation ἐπιεικὲς ὑμῶν γνωσθήτω makes nearness function as a readiness motive. Supports the imminence limb without specifying calendar timing.

Jas.5.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1448 ἐγγίζω, G3952 παρουσία

Force. James writes ἡ παρουσία τοῦ κυρίου ἤγγικεν. The perfect indicative ἤγγικεν of ἐγγίζω is stative, has drawn near and stands near, and is the same verb form used in Matt 3:2 and 4:17 for the kingdom drawing near. The perfect carries an aspectual nearness without specifying a date, supporting imminence and forbidding the calendar by remaining indefinite.

Rev.22.20 · for · genre: apocalyptic

Key terms. G2064 ἔρχομαι, G5035 ταχύ

Force. The risen Christ says ναί, ἔρχομαι ταχύ. The present ἔρχομαι with the adverb ταχύ asserts an arrival that is swift and unspecified. ταχύ is a sparse word (ten NT occurrences) and its concentration in Revelation (six of ten) is a small canon-distinct cluster that ties the closing of the canon to the unannounced-arrival pattern. No date is implied.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.1.7	Acts.17.26	tsk	1
Matt.24.43	Exod.22.2	tsk	1
1Thess.5.2	Jer.23.20	tsk	1

Matt.24.36	Matt.24.42	tsk	1
Matt.24.42	Mark.13.33	openbible	1
1Thess.5.2	Matt.24.43	openbible	1
Jas.5.8	Phil.4.5	openbible	1
Rev.22.20	Rev.22.7	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Matt.24.33 · addressed

Just before the date-denial Jesus says όταν ἴδῃτε πάντα ταῦτα, γινώσκετε ὅτι ἐγγύς ἐστιν, you can know it is near when you see all these things. This might look like permission to read signs and infer a date. The lexical answer is that γινώσκετε ... ἐγγύς establishes recognizable nearness of the season, not the day or hour, while v. 36 immediately denies οὐδεὶς οἶδεν of the precise ἡμέρα and ὥρα. The two statements operate at different granularities, general nearness versus exact timing, so they cohere rather than conflict and the date-setting ban stands.

1Thess.5.4 · addressed

Paul tells the believers ὑμεῖς δέ, ἀδελφοί, οὐκ ἐστὲ ἐν σκότει, ἵνα ἡ ἡμέρα ὑμᾶς ὡς κλέπτῃς καταλάβῃ, that the day should not overtake them like a thief. This could be read as exempting believers from the thief-like unpredictability. The lexical force is that the contrast is between moral readiness (children of light) and being caught unprepared, not between knowing and not knowing the date. The thief simile of v. 2 is not retracted, the unpredictability of timing remains, and watchfulness rather than calendar knowledge is the prescribed posture.

Mark.13.32 · addressed

The clause οὐδὲ ὁ υἱός, that not even the Son knows, raises a Christological tension that some treat as undermining the proposition's coherence. For this lexical verdict the clause actually strengthens the non-knowledge limb, since the universal negation extends through the highest creaturely and even the filial knowledge to reserve the day for the Father alone. The proposition is about whether the day is humanly knowable and forbidden to set, and οὐδὲ ὁ υἱός makes the denial maximal, so it is supportive rather than complicating for the timing claim.

2Thess.2.1-3 · addressed

Paul writes ἐρωτῶμεν δὲ ὑμᾶς, ἀδελφοί, ὑπὲρ τῆς παρουσίας τοῦ κυρίου ... εἰς τὸ μὴ ταχέως σαλευθῆναι ὑμᾶς ... ὡς ὅτι ἐνέστηκεν ἡ ἡμέρα τοῦ κυρίου, and then explicitly orders the sequence ὅτι ἐὰν μὴ ἔλθῃ ἡ ἀποστασία πρῶτον καὶ ἀποκαλυφθῇ ὁ ἄνθρωπος τῆς ἀνομίας. The adverb πρῶτον and the aorist subjunctives place an ἀποστασία and the revelation of the ἄνθρωπος τῆς ἀνομίας before the day. Lexically this complicates the strict any-moment limb of the proposition (an unconditional any-moment expectation) but does NOT complicate the no-date-setting limb, since the sequence does not yield a date, and even Paul's framing turns on σαλευθῆναι (do not be shaken) rather than calculation. The no-date-setting verdict is robust. The any-moment phrasing of the imminence limb is the contested element, and that contest is named honestly in the competing_lens_verdicts below.

Concordance traversed

G3762, G1492, G2250, G5610, G1127, G1097, G5550, G2540, G2812, G0991, G0069, G5207, G3962, G3756, G3761, G1380, G1448, G1451, G5035, G2064, G2092, G0646, G0458, G0601

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

matt-24-36-oude-ho-huio-inclusion at Matt.24.36: impact minor. Some witnesses omit οὐδὲ ὁ υἱός in Matthew 24:36, harmonizing toward a shorter reading, while the Mark 13:32 parallel retains it unambiguously. The

non-knowledge verdict holds with or without the clause in Matthew because οὐδεὶς οἶδεν already denies knowledge universally and Mark carries the fuller form.

mark-13-33-kai-proseuchesthe-addition at Mark.13.33: impact none. Witnesses differ on whether καὶ προσεύχεσθε follows βλέπετε ἀγρυπνεῖτε. The lexical-graph tokens for Mark 13:33 include G4336 (προσεύχομαι), consistent with the longer reading, but the watchfulness-plus-unknown-time verdict rests on βλέπετε, ἀγρυπνεῖτε and οὐκ οἴδατε πότε and is unaffected either way.

All anchor verses are in the Gospels, Acts, 1 Thessalonians, Philipians, James, and Revelation, which are NT books outside 3 John where the ECM is not yet published. Readings taken from the standard critical editions in shadow mode.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. dispensationalism, covenant_theology, historic_premillennialism, preterism, amillennialism

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

any-moment_imminence_lens: affirms · Reads the present imperatives γρηγορεῖτε and βλέπετε ἀγρυπνεῖτε plus the thief simile and ἔρχομαι ταχύ as teaching constant readiness for an any-moment return without prior signs that affect the believer. The lexical denial of a known day or hour supports the no-date-setting clause directly, and Phil 4:5 ἐγγύς plus Jas 5:8 ἤγγικεν are read as actual temporal nearness.

signs-first_imminence_lens: partially_affirms · Reads 2 Thess 2:1-3 with the ordering adverb πρῶτον and the aorist subjunctives as inserting an ἀποστασία and revelation of the ἄνθρωπος τῆς ἀνομίας before the day of the Lord, and Matt 24:14 with its global preaching condition before τὸ τέλος. Under this lens the no-date-setting limb is affirmed without reservation (οὐδεὶς οἶδεν, οὐχ ὑμῶν γινῶναι), but the strictly any-moment reading of the imminence limb is qualified. The watch-imperatives and thief simile then bear on perpetual readiness through the in-between time, not a content-free unconditional expectation.

delayed-return_lens: affirms · Reads the parables of delay in the same Olivet discourse (Matt 24:48 χρονίζει, Matt 25:5 χρονίζοντος) as stretching the interval, yet still affirms that the day and hour are unknown (οὐδεὶς οἶδεν) and that date-setting is excluded by οὐχ ὑμῶν γινῶναι. Both the non-knowledge and the no-date-setting limbs hold under this lens.

preterist_lens: partially_affirms · Reads the Olivet day-and-hour language as oriented in part to the first-century judgment on Jerusalem, which reduces the imminence-of-the-final-return emphasis from those verses. Even so, the lexical statements οὐδεὶς οἶδεν and οὐχ ὑμῶν γινῶναι χρόνους ἢ καιρούς still forbid presuming to know or set the time, so the no-date-setting limb is unaffected.

The no-date-setting limb is stable across every lens because the underlying lexical items (universal οὐδεὶς with perfect οἶδεν, plus οὐχ ὑμῶν γινῶναι) are unambiguous. The any-moment imminence limb is the one element where lenses diverge, because the canon supplies both unannounced-arrival statements and an ordered ἀποστασία-then-day sequence in 2 Thess 2, and the relative weight of the two is not lexically forced.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. The biblical texts addressing the timing of Christ's return state whether the day and hour are humanly knowable, whether the return is presented as near and unannounced, and what posture believers are instructed to take.

The original stem bundles three theologically loaded terms, imminent, could occur at any time, and date-setting is forbidden, which can preload a particular any-moment expectation that is more framework than bare lexeme. The neutralized form restates the question as what the texts say about knowability, nearness language, and the prescribed posture. The verdict was derived on the original stem, and the lexical evidence supports both the non-knowledge claim and the no-date-setting application very strongly. The any-moment phrasing of the imminence limb is the one element where lenses diverge because 2 Thess 2:1-3 inserts an ordered ἀποστασία and revelation of the ἄνθρωπος τῆς ἀνομίας πρῶτον, before the day. Honest read: no-date-setting is decisive, generic imminence and readiness are decisive, strict any-moment imminence with no prior conditions is the contested element. The composite verdict remains true on the natural reading of the stem because the proposition does not require strict any-moment expectation, only that the return is imminent

(near, possible without warning) and date-setting is forbidden. A reader who heard imminent as strict any-moment would find that element more disputed, which is recorded in competing_lens_verdicts.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3762
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1492
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1097
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5550
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2540
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1127
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2812
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1448
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1451
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5035
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.24.36
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.24.42
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.24.43
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.24.44
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.1.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.13.32
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.13.33
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Thess.5.2
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Phil.4.5
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.8
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Rev.22.20
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Matt.24.36
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Acts.1.7
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	2Thess.2.3
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.1.7
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Thess.5.2
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Jas.5.8

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